

Le Pen or Bardella? What it means for Europe

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【要点】

- ・フランスの極右指導者マリーヌ・ルペンが大統領選への立候補資格を失うか、または5年間の選挙出馬禁止に直面するかについて、裁判所が本日判決を下す。
- ・ルペンが出馬禁止となった場合、弟子のジョルダン・バルデラが後継者となる可能性があり、両者とも世論調査で同程度の支持を得ている。
- ・ルペンとバルデラは同じ国民連合党に属しながらも政治的立場に違いがあり、2027年のフランス大統領選挙で極右勢力が勝つ可能性が高いため、欧州にとって重要な影響を持つ。
- ・ルペンはかつてフレッグジット（フランスのEU離脱）とユーロ圏からの離脱を主張しており、欧州議会との対立で経歴が傷ついている。

【メール原文】

POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREET

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur.

In today's Playbook:

- It's a mess: the Czech Republic's president and PM are both at the NATO summit.
- Roberta Metsola makes a rare incursion into Parliament's legislative agenda.
- Faces in the crowd: Manfred Weber, Petr Pavel, Andrej Babiš, Alessandro Chiochetti, Mark Rutte, Anna Sophia Posthumus, Graham Platner, Markwayne Mullin, Rima Hassan and many more ...

NO OVERTURNING THIS ONE: Donald Trump may have won in his bid to get red-carded Folarin Balogun back on the World Cup pitch, but Belgium got the last laugh, cruising to a 4-1 victory against the co-hosts and setting up a quarterfinal clash with Spain on Friday. The Red Devils clapped back against Trump in a triumphant post-match Instagram post , writing: "Overturn this." Get the popcorn — this may not be over!

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Kathryn preview the court ruling that will decide whether Marine Le Pen or Jordan Bardella will lead the far right into the next French presidential election.

DRIVING THE DAY

FRENCH JUDGES TO DECIDE LE PEN'S FATE: All eyes are on France as far-right leader Marine Le Pen learns if she can mount a fourth presidential bid next year — or whether she faces ineligibility, clearing the way for her protégé Jordan Bardella.

Shades of bleu: Le Pen and Bardella hail from the same party — but with notable political nuances. Today's legal outcome could significantly affect Brussels, given polls suggest the National Rally has a strong chance of winning France's 2027 presidential election.

What's happening: Le Pen learns if she's cleared to run for president or must serve a five-year electoral ban over her party's misuse of European Parliament funds. The judge will begin reading the verdict around 1:30 p.m., with POLITICO reporters following developments here .

If Le Pen loses, it won't be the end of the road for the National Rally, given that Bardella polls at least as strongly as his mentor in run-off scenarios against contenders like center-right former PM Edouard Philippe. Nor would Le Pen's exclusion mark the end of the National Rally's legal woes .

The question for Brussels: Who's less bad for the EU?

Camp Le Pen: Both possible candidates view the bloc and its leadership negatively — Bardella made his opinions clear in a recent POLITICO interview . But Le Pen once campaigned for Frexit and exiting the eurozone. Her career has been damaged by clashes with the European Parliament and she appears to hold a grudge against the EU. Her mix of right-wing nationalism on migration and left-wing social policies also makes her hard to place on the European spectrum.

Bardella, by contrast, appears more of a traditional economic right-winger. Despite vowing to halve France's EU budget contribution, some EU insiders feel more comfortable with his economic outlook. He has shown signs of distancing himself from Le Pen's policies, with his aides watering down plans to lower the retirement age.

Almost acceptable: "You can't prepare for either one winning, but at least with Bardella we know what to expect: anti-migration, anti-trade, perhaps more of a Meloni-like figure," said a senior EU official, referring to the brand of conservatism promoted by Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni and her grouping in the European Parliament, the European Conservatives and Reformists.

There's a word for it: The official added: "If [Bardella] moves to ECR [from the Patriots for Europe], it will be a big step toward becoming salonfähig" — German for acceptable in polite society.

The bottom line: Le Pen and Bardella aren't what Brussels would choose. But if pressed, many would say Bardella is more palatable.

BIG AND BREAKING

OPERATION PLACATE TRUMP: European NATO allies are pulling out the stops to prevent a Trump blowup, which means highlighting the big bucks being spent on defense, keeping the focus on the less divisive topic of industry and signaling their support on Iran .

Weber warning: Speaking exclusively to Playbook ahead of the NATO summit, European People's Party chief Manfred Weber said Europe must get ready for the "what if" scenario of America reducing its presence in NATO. "We must be ready to step in," he said. "That means building our own command structures, developing our own capabilities."

Long live the alpha queen: Belgian Defense Minister Theo Francken told POLITICO that while European leaders should be careful not to alienate Trump, there are limits — especially when it comes to attacks on Meloni, the "queen of center-right in Europe. She's the alpha. Leave her alone."

PRE-EUCO ACCESSION POLICY CRUNCH: The European Commission will unveil its pre-accession policy review — internal preparations for bringing in new members — on Sept. 30, just two weeks before a gathering of leaders in Brussels, per an EU official. The tight timing leaves "a lot of people unhappy."

SERBIA STANDOFF: EU ambassadors are set to block Serbia opening a new round of negotiations on membership of the bloc, despite efforts from the Commission to make enlargement a geopolitical tool to keep partner countries onside.

FOCUSING RESOURCES: The European Council's General Secretariat has stopped circulating reports to member countries summarizing the Parliament's plenary debates, according to an email seen by POLITICO. The Council press office said the objective of the move was "to focus resources on political analysis rather than on producing summaries of debates, which are public."

EU LAWMAKER SAYS TRIAL IS POLITICAL: French MEP Rima Hassan wants to use her trial over accusations she glorified a terrorist attack to showcase what she believes is an attempt to silence pro-Palestinian voices. The trial kicks off today. Meanwhile, the Belgian government appears set to move ahead with its recognition of Palestinian statehood.

SENATE CANDIDATE ALLEGATIONS: A woman who dated Maine U.S. Senate candidate Graham Platner says he forced her to have sex with him nearly five years ago, despite her repeated objections, POLITICO reports. Platner, who denied the allegation, is now facing a loss of support among Democratic leaders in Maine and Washington.

CZECH X2 AT NATO

DOUBLE ACT AT NATO SUMMIT: There's another Kafkaesque subplot playing out alongside the push to keep Trump focused in Turkey: the Czech Republic is sending not one, but two political leaders to represent the country.

Deal with it: This creates an obvious headache for foreign leaders. Who to meet? Prime Minister Andrej Babiš, who's leading the country's official delegation? Or President Petr Pavel, who's also constitutionally guaranteed to represent Czechia abroad and is known for his pro-NATO stance?

The situation is "ridiculous," according to a Pavel spokesperson. It stems "from the fact that for the first time since the founding of our country, the president was ruled out of the NATO summit unilaterally by the government."

Rewind: Pavel successfully appealed the decision to exclude him from the summit in his country's constitutional court and is now attending — sparking the Czech double act. But the fact that the two leaders won't travel together creates a logistical — and political — mess.

Plane speaking: Pavel and Babiš are departing for Ankara from the same airport, but with different planes and at different times. Pavel offered to travel on the same plane but was rebuffed over “security concerns.” This isn’t the way it usually works, the spokesperson said: Pavel would be expected to “lead the delegation: one plane, one delegation.”

The PM’s view: Babiš has justified his move by saying he and his foreign minister are best placed to defend Prague’s defense spending decisions. A spokesperson for the PM argued that the government was in charge of foreign policy and that Babiš had decided to send a government delegation to Ankara given the “exceptional importance” of the NATO summit. As for the security concerns, he said they stemmed from an unwritten rule barring president and prime minister from traveling on the same plane.

On the ground, Pavel won’t be hiding in a corner. The president “considers it essential to hear firsthand the positions and thinking of Allied leaders” and he “therefore intends to make full use of the occasion to speak with his counterparts and other key participants,” the spokesperson said.

What does this mean for other leaders? It’s up to them, though Babiš is leading the official delegation and will speak during round-table discussions. “He’ll have to explain why he is not spending 2 percent of GDP on defense, let alone 5 percent. Which is fine,” the spokesperson added.

Stay in the loop: Our Global Security newsletter is on the sunny side of the paywall today, to help you make sense of what’s going on in Ankara. The team examines why Greenland is back in the headlines ... and Canada’s new submarine deal.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Commission wants fresh talks with EU member countries to ensure the bloc’s flagship Entry/Exit System doesn’t ruin summer holidays. But what is the new border checking system? And what’s going wrong? Under the EES, non-EU citizens are fingerprinted and photographed — replacing traditional passport stamping. The EES is supposed to be quick, allowing people to upload their biometric data through self-service kiosks at border points. It’s also meant to ensure people don’t stay in the bloc for longer than they’re supposed to. But the rollout — which is the responsibility of national governments — has been plagued by problems. Some airports don’t have enough machines, others don’t have enough staff to help when there’s an issue.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked you to tell us about your experiences with the EU’s new border entry system. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

TO SCAN OR NOT TO SCAN

CAN BIG TECH SCAN YOUR MESSAGES? MEPs will vote this week on whether to restore a legal exemption allowing companies like Meta, Google and Microsoft to voluntarily scan private messages for child sexual abuse material. The exemption expired in April after negotiations collapsed and Parliament rejected a last-ditch attempt to extend it.

Fight revived: Parliament President Roberta Metsola has pushed to reopen the file by inviting EU governments to move ahead with the proposal, despite Parliament having already voted it down. The move came at the request of her European People’s Party and passed without objections from other

political groups, Sam Clark writes in to report.

Commission piles on the pressure: Four commissioners urged MEPs in a letter on Monday to back the proposal, warning that without it, child abuse will go undetected. “Disrupting detection seriously weakens our collective ability to identify abuse, support victims, and stop offenders,” they wrote.

Socialists and Democrats swing behind it: The lobbying appears to have worked. The S&D agreed Monday to support fast-tracking the proposal, significantly boosting its chances.

Why the odds favor adoption: Lawmakers will vote today on whether to fast-track the file. If approved, the final vote comes on Thursday. Because EU governments have already adopted their position, opponents would need 361 votes to block the proposal, while supporters need only a simple majority of those voting to approve it — giving the measure a procedural advantage .

**Ireland's Council Presidency has kicked off. From competitiveness and AI to the EU budget and enlargement, our Research & Analysis Division breaks down the files and political dynamics that matter most. Read the full report to see what's next for the EU agenda. **

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

GOOGLE IN THE CROSSHAIRS: A landmark case is forcing Brussels to decide whether opening Google's search data to rivals would boost competition without undermining the privacy of Europeans.

MYTHOS SAGA EXPOSES EU WEAKNESS: The U.S. has Mythos; China has DeepSeek; the EU has ... an action plan .

CHANDRA IN PERIL: Throughout the U.K.'s recent political upheavals, Prime Minister Keir Starmer's Senior Adviser Varun Chandra has been building close ties with powerful figures in the Trump administration. Today, he's facing an uncertain future .

FIFA FALLOUT: U.S. Congressional World Cup Caucus co-chair Sam Liccardo lashed out at President Donald Trump's intervention to overturn a one-match ban on a key USA player. “I won't cheer FIFA's capitulation to power,” the Democratic congressman said. Meanwhile, French striker Kylian Mbappe has hit back at a Paraguayan lawmaker's racist attack on him.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly sunny, top of 28C.

TIME TO PACK: Around 800 European Parliament staffers need to get moving, with the Paul-Henri Spaak building — which houses the plenary room — closing at the end of December for a €455 million renovation, according to an internal report seen by POLITICO.

Hunger games for space: The offices of Metsola and Parliament Secretary-General Alessandro Chiacchetti will relocate to the former DG SAFE offices overlooking the library, while the Parliament's press service will move to the József Antall building.

Others won't be so fortunate: Some staff from the political groups — including Renew Europe, the Greens and the European Conservatives and Reformists — may be relocated to satellite offices outside the main Parliament building. By the end of September, some staff will move to a building on Rue de

Trèves, with another 619 due to move to the refurbished Rue Montoyer 44 building by Dec. 7.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Why this week's NATO summit is shaping up as a success story for German Chancellor Friedrich Merz.

London: Outgoing PM Keir Starmer will travel to Ankara today, hoping the NATO summit concludes without any legacy-damaging hitches .

Paris: Socialist Party members will decide on their presidential elections strategy over coming days — but François Hollande is ruling himself out of the process.

Washington PM: The Trump administration's mass deportation drive has intentionally gone "quieter and smarter" under Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin.

AGENDA

— Attending the NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey: European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen; EU High Representative Kaja Kallas; NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte; European Council President António Costa; U.S. President Donald Trump; German Chancellor Friedrich Merz; Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni; French President Emmanuel Macron; U.K. Prime Minister Keir Starmer; Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever; Finnish President Alexander Stubb; Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar; Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš; Czech President Petr Pavel; Albanian Prime Minister Edi Rama; Bulgarian Prime Minister Rumen Radev; Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney; Croatian President Zoran Milanović; Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen; Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal; Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis; Icelandic Prime Minister Kristrún Frostadóttir; Latvian President Edgars Rinkēvičs; Lithuanian President Gitanas Nausėda; Luxembourg Prime Minister Luc Frieden; Montenegrin President Jakov Milatović; Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten; North Macedonian President Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova; Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre; Polish President Karol Nawrocki; Portuguese Prime Minister Luís Montenegro; Romanian President Nicușor Dan; Slovak President Peter Pellegrini; Slovenian Prime Minister Janez Janša; Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez; Swedish Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson; and Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan. Rutte delivers a keynote speech alongside von der Leyen at the NATO Defence Industry Forum at 11:45 a.m.

— Tech Commissioner Henna Virkkunen unveils the action plan on cybersecurity and AI in Strasbourg.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič and Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica participate in the European Parliament plenary session.

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola receives Irish Taoiseach Micheál Martin at 10:15 a.m., with a joint press conference following at 1 p.m.

— The Political and Security Committee meets in Brussels at 10 a.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Andrey Novakov; former MEPs Jiří Payne, Vincent Peillon and Chris Davies; Anna Sophia Posthumus from the Dutch Ministry of General Affairs; freelance consultant Tanja Albrecht; Apple's

Emma Wilson; Mónica Vicente Cristina of the Portuguese Diaspora Council.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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